Midterm Elections

The USA, November 2026



Warm-up

Who would you vote for?



Troy Jackson

- Logger from Allagash, northern Maine
- Former President of the Maine State Senate



Susan Collins

- Grew up in Caribou, northern Maine
- U.S. Senator from Maine since 1997

What do they stand for?

Troy Jackson (Democrat)

- Medicare for All: government health insurance for everyone
- Abolish ICE, the immigration agency he calls "rogue"
- Opposes the war with Iran; would never vote for military aid to Israel
- Protect abortion rights in federal law

Susan Collins (Republican)

- Says she votes against her own party more than any other senator
- Voted against Trump's "One Big Beautiful Bill" (2025)
- Supports abortion rights — but voted to confirm Justice Kavanaugh, who helped overturn *Roe v. Wade*
- Chairs the committee that controls federal spending

Do you still feel confident in your vote?

Most voters are not well informed

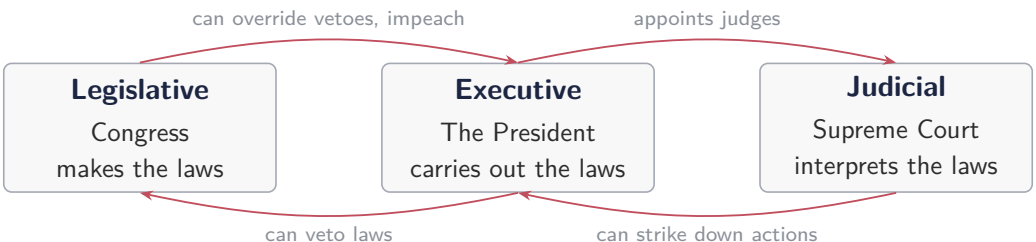
- Only 65% of Americans can name all three branches of government
- Only about half know which party controls each chamber of Congress
- Many voters decide based on party, name recognition, or a single ad

Source: Annenberg Public Policy Center, Civics Surveys (2024, 2026).

What Is a Midterm?

Basic civics: three branches

The U.S. government is divided into three coequal branches in a system of checks and balances.



Text Analysis

James Wilson, signer of the Constitution and one of the first Supreme Court justices, *Lectures on Law* (1791)

> *"The executive as well as the legislative power ought to be restrained. . . . The restraints on the legislative authority, must from its nature, be chiefly internal; that is, they must proceed from some part or division of itself. But the restraints on the executive power are external. These restraints are applied with the greatest certainty, and with greatest efficacy, when the object of restraint is clearly ascertained. This is best done, when one object only, distinguished and responsible, is conspicuously held up to the view and examination of the publick [sic]. . . . "*

Text Analysis

James Wilson, *Lectures on Law* (1791), continued

> *". . . In planning, forming and arranging laws, deliberation is always becoming, and always useful. But in the active scenes of government, there are emergencies, in which the man, as, in other cases, the women [sic], who deliberates is lost. Secrecy may be equally necessary as dispatch. But, can either secrecy or dispatch be expected, when, to every enterprise, mutual communication, mutual consultation, and mutual agreement among men, perhaps of discordant views, of discordant tempers, and of discordant interests, are indispensably necessary? How much time will be consumed!"*

Compare: the USA and Austria

	USA	Austria
Who runs the government?	The President	The Chancellor
How are they chosen?	Elected separately from Congress	Needs a majority in parliament (*Nationalrat*)
Head of state	The President (same person)	The Federal President (mostly ceremonial)
National elections	Every 2 years	Every 5 years

Congress: the legislative branch

Congress has two chambers:

- **House of Representatives**
  - 435 members, 2-year terms
  - Seats divided by population
- **Senate**
  - 100 members, 6-year terms
  - 2 senators per state, no matter the size
  - *Filibuster:* most bills need 60 of 100 votes



The U.S. Capitol, Washington, D.C.

What is a midterm?

- The President serves **four-year** terms
- Midterms are congressional elections halfway through a President's term
  - All 435 House seats and about a third of the Senate
  - 2026: Tuesday, **November 3**

What usually happens?

- Public opinion is "thermostatic": it shifts against the party in power
- In effect, the President's party and positions become more and more unpopular

Think

Given this trend, what would we expect to happen in the midterms?

Buyer's remorse

> *"He tells you one thing and does just the opposite."*

— Trump voter in Iowa, on gas and food prices (MS NOW, 2026)

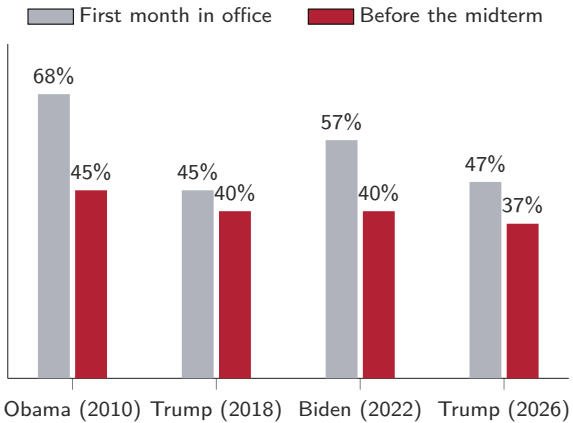
> *"It just seems like everything has gone downhill."*

— Richard, 56, voted Biden in 2020 and Trump in 2024 (NPR focus group, 2026)

> *"I've been so disappointed that I'm just going to go straight and just do Democrat, Democrat, Democrat."*

— Karla, 49, voted Republican in 2024 (NPR focus group, 2026)

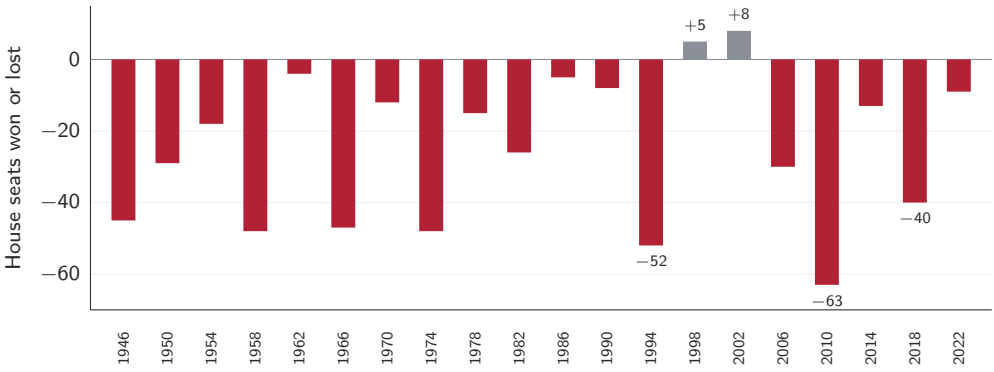
Presidents get less popular



- Every recent President was less popular at the midterm than at the start
- One in five 2024 Trump voters now say they regret their vote

Presidential job approval. Sources: Gallup; 2026 value is the polling average as of Oct. 16, 2026. Regret figure: Navigator Research (Sept. 2026).

The President's party almost always loses seats



The President's party lost House seats in 18 of 20 midterms since 1946. When the President's approval is below 50%, the average loss is 37 seats.

Sources: University of Michigan Center for Political Studies; Gallup.

The 2026 Midterms

Where things stand

- Trump is extremely unpopular: about 37% approve (one poll: 31%, his lowest ever)
- Democrats are **heavily favored** to retake the House and **favored** to take the Senate

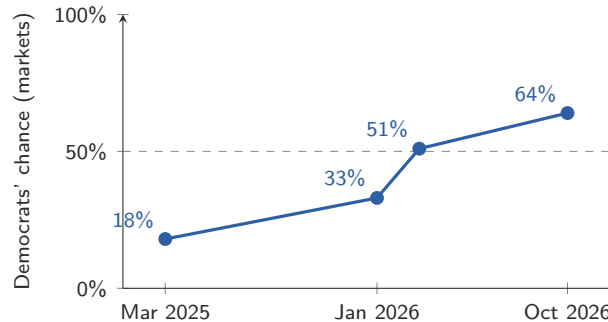
91%	94%	64%	75%
House	House	Senate	Senate
Polymarket	Nate Silver	Polymarket	Nate Silver

Chance that Democrats win control, mid-October 2026

Polymarket is a betting market; Nate Silver's Silver Bulletin is a statistical forecast.

Democrats: a real shot at the Senate

- Republicans hold the Senate **53–47**
- Democrats need to gain 4 seats
- In early 2025, this looked almost impossible



Approximate prediction-market prices (Polymarket and Kalshi), as reported by Yahoo News and Polymarket.

Democrats: flipping red states?



James Talarico

Texas ▪ vs. Ken Paxton (R)

- Texas hasn't elected a Democrat to the Senate since 1988
- Polls: Talarico ahead by about 2 points



Mary Peltola

Alaska ▪ vs. Sen. Dan Sullivan (R)

- Alaska hasn't elected a Democrat to the Senate since 2008
- Polls: very close, Peltola slightly ahead

Photos: Antonioaesparza, CC BY-SA 4.0; U.S. House of Representatives.

But also: Democratic infighting

The Maine Senate race

- **June:** Graham Platner, an oyster farmer and Marine veteran backed by Bernie Sanders, wins the primary over Governor Janet Mills
- **July 10:** Platner drops out after a sexual assault allegation (which he denies) and other scandals: old Reddit posts and a tattoo resembling a Nazi symbol
- **Troy Jackson** had just lost the primary for governor (3rd place)
- **July 25:** The party picks Jackson as the new candidate at a convention
- Mills refuses to endorse him; Collins has more money in the bank
- Today: a toss-up, Jackson ahead by about 2 points



Jackson (D)



Collins (R)

Read aloud

Candidate A on Candidate B:

> *"We don't need a celebrity candidate. . . . It didn't work out, so he started the podcast, he wrote the books, and now he's running for Senate."*

Candidate B's answer:

> *"Congresswoman, if you enjoy podcasts about public health, I welcome you to take a listen."*

Surprise: they are in the same party!



Candidate A:
Haley Stevens



Candidate B:
Abdul El-Sayed

- Both are Democrats, from the 2026 Michigan Senate primary
- Moderate vs. progressive
- Stevens and her allies spent about 9 times more on ads
- El-Sayed won, 48.5% to 47.5%
- He now faces Republican Mike Rogers

Quotes: Michigan Senate primary debate, July 27, 2026. Ad spending: AdImpact via CNBC.

How have Republicans responded?

- Facing bad polls, Trump and the Republicans have tried to change the rules before November
- **Supporters say:** the new rules stop non-citizens from voting and prevent fraud
- **Critics say:** non-citizen voting is extremely rare; the real goal is to make voting harder and tilt the election
- Three main strategies:
  1. New voting laws (the SAVE America Act)
  2. Limiting mail-in voting
  3. Redrawing district maps

New voting rules

The SAVE America Act

- Would require **proof of citizenship** (e.g. a passport) to register and a **photo ID** to vote
- Passed the House in February, 218–213
- Stuck in the Senate: not enough votes to beat the filibuster
- Trump has demanded that the Senate abolish the filibuster

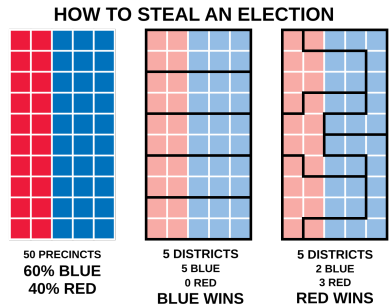
Trump's mail-in voting order

- Signed March 31, 2026
- The Postal Service would refuse to deliver mail ballots to anyone not on a government-approved list
- September: the Supreme Court blocked it for 2026, 7–2
- Mail voting this year works as usual

Sources: NBC News; Votebeat.

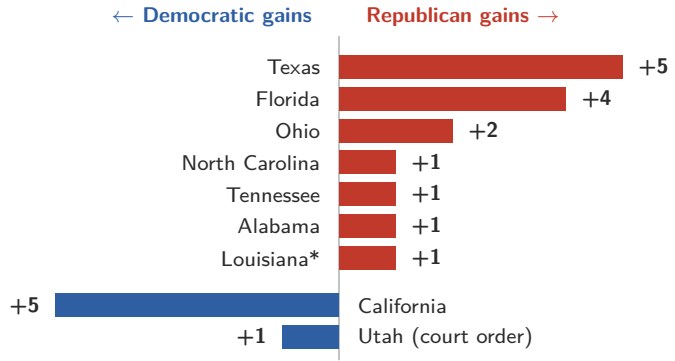
Mid-decade redistricting

- Each state draws its own House districts, normally **once every 10 years**, after the census
- **Gerrymandering:** drawing district lines so that one party wins more seats than its share of votes
- **2025:** Trump pushed Texas to redraw its map in the middle of the decade to create 5 new Republican seats
- California answered with its own Democratic map — and a "map war" began



Same voters, different maps. Diagram: Steve Nass, CC BY-SA 4.0

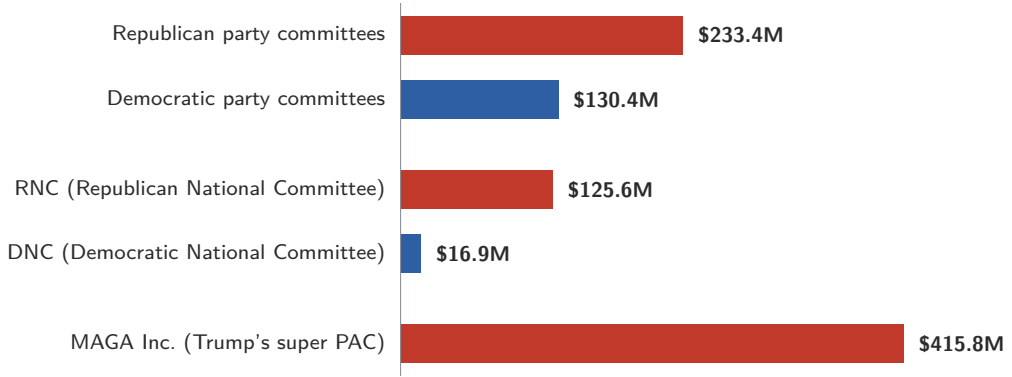
The map war: new seats for 2026



Net effect: roughly +9 seats for Republicans. Virginia's Democratic map was struck down by its state court; Indiana Republicans refused to redraw.

Estimated seat gains. *Louisiana's map is being challenged in court. Source: Wikipedia, "2025–2026 United States redistricting."

Money: Republicans have far more cash



The DNC is also $17.6 million in debt.

Cash on hand at the end of August 2026. Source: FEC filings via CNBC.

Money: where does it come from, where does it go?

Where it comes from

- **Billionaires:** Elon Musk is the biggest donor of 2026; Miriam Adelson gave about $68 million
- **Tech & crypto:** the founders of Andreessen Horowitz gave $115 million; the crypto super PAC Fairshake has over $140 million
- **But:** many Democratic *candidates* raise more from small online donors (Jackson: $20 million+)

Where it goes

- Super PACs can spend unlimited money, as long as they don't coordinate with candidates
- Musk gave $158 million to the Senate Leadership Fund, which sent $158 million to Texas to fight Talarico
- Most of it pays for TV and online ads in battleground states

Sources: Washington Post; Forbes; Public Citizen; AP; FEC.

If we have time: the ads

See how the money plays out in the Senate battlegrounds:

- **Maine:** Troy Jackson vs. Susan Collins
- **Texas:** James Talarico vs. Ken Paxton
- **Alaska:** Mary Peltola vs. Dan Sullivan
- **Michigan:** Abdul El-Sayed vs. Mike Rogers

Final Activity

Now you are informed voters



Troy Jackson (D)



Susan Collins (R)

- Revisit your choice from the start of the lesson
- Choose a candidate
- Justify your answer!